Production Incident Response Runbook

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1. Severity Levels

Severity	Definition	Response time	Update cadence
SEV1	Full outage or data loss affecting many customers	15 minutes	Every 30 minutes
SEV2	Major feature broken, no workaround, many customers	30 minutes	Every 60 minutes
SEV3	Partial degradation or workaround exists	4 business hours	Daily
SEV4	Minor bug, cosmetic issue	Next sprint	None

2. Declaring an Incident

Anyone can declare an incident. Type /incident declare in the #incidents Slack channel and choose a severity. The on-call engineer for the affected service becomes the Incident Commander (IC) until they hand off. For SEV1 and SEV2, the IC must page the Engineering Manager on call and open a Zoom bridge within 10 minutes.

3. Roles

- Incident Commander: coordinates the response and makes decisions; does not debug.
- Operations Lead: investigates and applies fixes.
- Communications Lead: posts status page updates and informs Customer Support.
- Scribe: keeps a timeline in the incident document.

4. Mitigation First

The first goal is to stop customer impact, not to find the root cause. Preferred mitigations, in order: roll back the latest deployment, disable the feature flag, fail over to the secondary region (us-east-2), scale out the affected service. Rollbacks do not require approval during an active SEV1 or SEV2.

5. Customer Communication

For SEV1 incidents the status page at status.helios.example.com must be updated within 20 minutes of declaration. Customer Support must be notified in #support-escalations. Enterprise customers with a premium SLA receive a direct email from their Customer Success Manager within 1 hour.

6. Postmortems

A blameless postmortem is required for every SEV1 and SEV2 incident. The postmortem document must be published within 5 business days of resolution and reviewed in the weekly Reliability Review meeting. Every postmortem must include a timeline, root cause, impact (customers affected and duration), and at least one action item with an owner and due date. Action items from SEV1 postmortems must be completed within 30 days.